GLASSHOUSE

FUTURE IMPERFECT

As the assembly polls in Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh and Rajasthan draw to a close, the future of the 18 MPs that the BJP fielded, four of whom were Union ministers, has become the subject of intense speculation. Three of the Union ministers–**Narendra Singh Tomar**, **Prahlad Patel** and **Faggan Singh Kulaste**–are from MP, where the ruling BJP and challenger Congress are in a close contest. Every seat counts, and that will require the ministers to stay put in the state, whether to form the government or to strengthen the party's hands in the Opposition. If the BJP wins, expect a tussle over the chief ministerial chair. With the Lok Sabha election less than six months away, the central leadership may induce a temporary truce, but the party is certain to have its hands full later.



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

Killing Time







The election behind them, top leaders in Rajasthan are finding special ways to spend time till D-day (December 3). Chief Minister **Ashok Gehlot** visited elder sister Vimla Devi and then flew to Telangana to campaign for the Congress there. He is reportedly in touch with several independent candidates, including rebels, in case their 'help' is needed to form government. The BJP's ex-CM **Vasundhara Raje** took a trip to the Tripura Sundari temple (again) before going to meet senior RSS leader Nimba Ram (again). Meanwhile, Union home minister **Amit Shah**, who had claimed the BJP would win a two-third majority, is monitoring the independent candidates... just in case the party needs 'outside support' come government formation time.

That Empty Feeling



The BJP's Jhalkari Bai Jayanti Samaroh in Patna on November 25 was meant to be a show of strength ahead of ex-ally JD(U)'s Bheem Sansad the next day. But not even the presence of top state leaders could save the BJP the embarrassment of low attendance. Especially as CM and JD (U) boss **Nitish Kumar** generated a few laughs over it at his event the next day. The BJP brass has now sent out a diktat about ensuring 'no vacant chairs' at future party programmes.

SKILFUL MOVE

Tamil Nadu CM **M.K. Stalin** is "broadening the reach" of the popular Naan Mudhalvan (I am on top) upskilling platform, which imparts industry-relevant skills to the youth. Operations are being outsourced for upgrades to make it "content-rich, dynamic and high-performing". Stalin's pet project has already helped train 370,000 youth across the state. Of course, the move for "greater efficiency" is also with an eye on the youth vote in the 2024 general election.



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

STALLED SHOW



The Gujarat government has been having a tough time lately, with even BJP leaders taking pot shots at it. Union MoS for communications **Devusinh Chauhan** was the latest, publicly berating the district administration during a visit to a Narmada village on November 20 as part of the Viksit Bharat Sankalp Yatra (a campaign to spread awareness about central schemes). This was after a villager complained to the Gujarat MP that she had long been waiting for her income certificate (needed to avail state health benefits) from the village *talati*. Chauhan, who seemed to be at the end of his tether, blasted the officials for their callousness. For good measure, he also directed the district collector to cancel the contract for his campaign rath. Apparently, it had no working videos on central schemes.

Kaushik Deka with Rohit Parihar, Jumana Shah, Amitabh Srivastava and Amarnath K. Menon